

Simplicity

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The Concept and Difficulties Associated with It

Among the traditionally recognized divine attributes regularly discussed by medieval theologians and accepted by them as part of orthodox religious belief, the strangest and hardest to understand is simplicity. Nonetheless, for all the difficulty of the doctrine of simplicity, philosophers and theologians in all three major monotheisms – Judaism, Christianity, and Islam – have seen it as foundational for understanding the divine nature. In their view, God is an absolutely perfect being, and absolute perfection requires simplicity.

The doctrine of simplicity is the doctrine that God is one in a radical sort of way; a simple God lacks composition of any sort. The doctrine can be thought of as comprising four claims.

- 1 God cannot have any spatial or temporal parts.
- 2 God cannot have any intrinsic accidental properties.
- 3 There cannot be any real distinction between one essential property and another in God's nature.
- 4 There cannot be a real distinction between essence and existence in God.

These claims rule out composition in increasingly strict ways.

Claim (1), which is the easiest to understand, rules out the possibility that God is a physical entity or even is spatially locatable, as immaterial ghosts are sometimes supposed to be (see Chapter 34, Incorporeality). Claim (1) has also regularly been taken to imply that God is eternal rather than temporal: on the doctrine of simplicity, the life of a simple God is not spread out over time, any more than God is spread out over space (see Chapter 32, Eternity). Although the idea that God is not corporeal is familiar, not everyone finds the doctrine of God's eternality comprehensible or consistent. Some philosophers have supposed that an eternal God couldn't act in time, and some philosophers have argued that the notion of an atemporal life is incoherent.

Claim (2) presupposes the familiar distinction between intrinsic and extrinsic properties, or between real properties and Cambridge properties (as they are sometimes called). Although this distinction is widely used and often easy to apply, it is difficult to give a precise and satisfactory account of it. The basic notion behind it is, roughly, that a change in *s*'s extrinsic properties can occur without a change in *s*, while a change in *s*'s intrinsic properties is a change in *s*. The intrinsic properties of an abstract geometrical figure are all essential to it. On the doctrine of simplicity, God is like this, too, in the sense that none of his intrinsic properties are accidental. Like every other entity, however, God has extrinsic accidental properties, such as his being mentioned on this page.

The implications of claim (2) are, on the face of it, counterintuitive. They are also difficult to square with the traditional account of God, according to which God freely chooses to do some things, including respond to human free choices. So, for example, God has the property of being such that he freely answers the prayer Hannah freely chooses to pray by bringing about the birth of her son Samuel. But, according to claim (2), any such property is essential to God. Presumably, then, it is not possible for God to exist and not have such a property, and therefore God has no choice about whether he has it or not. It is hard to see, then, in what sense God's response to Hannah can be free or dependent on Hannah's freely choosing to pray her prayer.

Such difficulties are only exacerbated by claim (3), which denies the possibility of distinguishing one essential attribute of God's from another. From this claim it seems to follow that God's being such that he answers Hannah's prayer must be identical with any other attribute of God's, including, for example, being such that he talks with Rebecca about her pregnancy. Furthermore, any such attribute of God's will be identical with any of the more widely recognized divine attributes, like omniscience (see Chapter 28); and omniscience will be identical with omnipotence (see Chapter 27), which will also be identical with perfect goodness (see Chapter 30) and every other property of God's.

Finally, claim (4) makes it clear that all talk of attributes is misleading, on the doctrine of simplicity. If we could distinguish attributes within God, then we could also make a distinction within God between the existent God and the essence that God has. But according to claim (4), God is so radically one that there is no composition in him even of essence and existence. Consequently, God does not have an essence; instead, he is identical with his essence, and even his existence cannot be distinguished from that essence.

Many but not all of these apparently counterintuitive consequences can be warded off by clarifying the view of God's nature that the doctrine of simplicity is meant to express. On the doctrine of simplicity, it is misleading to think of God's answering Hannah's prayer as, literally, one of the things God does. Rather, strictly speaking, the one thing that atemporal God has is a variety of effects in time: a promise to Hagar at t_1 , a conversation with Rebecca at t_2 , and a response to Hannah at t_3 . The absence of real distinction among divine attributes such as omniscience and omnipotence can be explained analogously. What human beings distinguish conceptually as divine omniscience and omniscience is the single thing that is God but recognized by us under differing descriptions or in different manifestations. On the doctrine of simplicity, although all the designations for divine attributes are identical in reference, they are nonetheless

not synonymous but are rather different in sense, just as “the morning star” and “the evening star” are non-synonymous expressions designating the same thing under different descriptions or in different manifestations. Furthermore, that omnipotence and omniscience are different manifestations of the same thing doesn’t entail that power and knowledge are the same.

The most recalcitrant difficulties generated by the doctrine of simplicity are those that result from combining the doctrine with the traditional ascription to God of free will. How can it be both that God freely willed to create (see Chapter 37, Creation and Conservation), for example, and also that God has no intrinsic accidental attributes? If God freely willed to create, isn’t it the case that he might have willed not to create, so that there are possible worlds in which God doesn’t create? But if that is so, then God isn’t the same in all possible worlds; in some worlds, he has an attribute, namely, the attribute of being such that he creates, which he doesn’t have in other worlds. But then it does seem that God has intrinsic accidental attributes.

Part of the trouble here comes from combining the medieval terminology of the doctrine of simplicity with contemporary understandings of the same terms. Although Thomas Aquinas, for example, denies that God has any intrinsic accidental attributes, he does not mean that God is the same in every possible world in which he exists. For much of the medieval period, modalities were not thought of in terms of sameness or difference across possible worlds but rather in terms of branching timelines of the actual world. So, for example, although Aquinas sees God’s not creating as logically possible, God’s creating is nonetheless not an accident of God’s, but is rather necessary to him – in the sense that there is no branch of this world’s timeline on which not willing to create is correctly ascribable to God. For Aquinas, then, to deny that God has intrinsic accidents is to hold that God’s nature is immutably and determinately the same for all time in this world, not that it is the same across all possible worlds.

Someone might nonetheless object that the difference between those of God’s attributes which are the same in all possible worlds and those which aren’t marks a real distinction in God’s nature, between the metaphysical “softness” of willing to create, for example, and the metaphysical “hardness” of God’s omnipotence. It isn’t clear, however, that this conceptual distinction constitutes a metaphysical distinction in God. Although some of the objects of God’s will might have been different, it isn’t the case that there are parts of the divine will which are more mutable or less ineluctable than others (see Chapter 38, Immutability and Impassibility). What the conceptual distinction picks out is a difference in the ways in which God is related to himself and to other things, but being related differently to different things doesn’t entail that there are distinct intrinsic properties in God.

Many philosophers nonetheless suppose that these difficulties and others as well are fatal to the doctrine of divine simplicity. Some argue that the doctrine is incoherent, and others maintain that it is inconsistent with certain other traditionally held claims about God. To some philosophers, for example, a simple God seems to have more the nature of an abstract object than the character of a person. Still others suppose that there is no way of reconciling the doctrine of simplicity with the doctrine of the Trinity (see Chapter 82, Philosophical Reflection on Revelation and Scripture).

The History of the Concept

The concept of simplicity can be found in Plotinus (see, for example, *Enneads* V.1–3), who attributes it to Parmenides and Plato, although it is perhaps more accurately attributable to earlier commentators on Plato. For Plotinus, the doctrine of divine simplicity is a powerful impetus to negative theology, showing that God is to be understood only in terms of what he is not, rather than in terms of any positive attributes which can be correctly applied to him. (The same impetus to negative theology can also be seen clearly in the use Maimonides makes of the doctrine [see Chapter 11, *The Jewish Contribution to Medieval Philosophical Theology*].) The Church Fathers also have a notion of simplicity and apply it to God. It or something ancestral to it can be found in Origen (see, for example, *Peri Archon* I.1.6). Athanasius supposes that accepting composition of essence and qualities in God will be generally shocking to the orthodox (*Epistola ad Afros Episcopos* 8).

The concept receives a good deal of attention in the work of Augustine, who combines the logic of Aristotle's *Categories* with Neoplatonic attitudes toward metaphysics and theology. So, for example, Augustine argues that in God there is none of the difference between accident and substance of the sort that characterizes creatures; rather, as Augustine puts it, God is what he has (*De Civitate Dei* XI.10). Augustine recognizes a worry about the compatibility of simplicity and Trinity, but he sees the difficulties more in the doctrine of the Trinity itself than in the combination of the two doctrines. According to the doctrine of the Trinity, God is three persons but only one substance; the persons of the Trinity are distinguished from one another only by relational attributes and not by any intrinsic essential or accidental properties, all of which are identical among the three persons. Augustine recognizes the perplexing nature of these claims, but he sees no special difficulty in holding that the one thing that all the persons of the Trinity are is itself simple (see, for example, *De Trinitate* VI.6–8).

Anselm takes any composition to be incompatible with aseity. If God is just because he has justice, then he has justice from something external to himself, on which he is dependent, Anselm thinks, and so he is not self-sufficient, contrary to what we suppose about the deity. Since similar considerations apply to any property attributed to God, Anselm holds that anything that can be truly said of God is the same as God's essence and that God is without any composition at all (*Monologion* 16–18). In the *Proslogion*, he deduces God's simplicity from the characterization of God as "that than which nothing greater can be conceived of" (*Proslogion* 12).

The culmination of medieval Latin discussions of simplicity comes in the work of Aquinas. In *Summa Theologiae* I.3, Aquinas presents the notion of divine simplicity by denying composition of God in increasingly strenuous ways. There is in God, he says, no composition of matter and form, so that God is not material. Furthermore, God is identical with his nature, and his nature is identical with his existence. Consequently, he has no accidents, and his essence cannot be divided into various attributes. In *Quaestiones Disputatae de Potentia* he argues that although the words characterizing divine attributes refer to one and the same thing, they are not synonymous (I.7.6). Furthermore, although these terms cannot be predicated of God and creatures

univocally, it must not be thought that they are therefore predicated equivocally. Instead, they are predicated analogously, so that, for example, while divine and human justice cannot be defined in exactly the same way, divine justice is analogous to human justice.

Aquinas' account of simplicity is informed not only by the work of his Christian predecessors but also by a long tradition of philosophical and theological discussion among Jewish and Islamic philosophers. In the opening chapter of his work on the Mishnah Torah, Maimonides considers the command to the Jews to worship only one God. He sees the commandment not only as forbidding polytheism, but also as warding off wrong views of the nature of God. According to Maimonides, the commandment mandates ruling out any sort of composition in God. In *The Guide of the Perplexed* Maimonides spells out his interpretation of the doctrine of simplicity, including a denial of any distinction between essence and existence in God (chs. 14–18). Furthermore, he thinks that because God is simple, terms applied to God and creatures are used equivocally, and the only attributes which can be predicated of God, strictly speaking, are negative attributes. We are nonetheless not left without knowledge of God, because the negative attributes, in showing us what God is not, give us some significant information about him. Positive attributes customarily applied to God are to be understood in a negative way; so, for instance, when we say that God is living, what we should understand by this expression is that it is not the case that God is dead (ch. 18). Although Aquinas accepted a great deal of Maimonides' interpretation of simplicity, he rejected this way of understanding predicates applied to God and creatures.

Maimonides was himself reacting to an important controversy within Arabic philosophical theology (see Chapter 10, *The Islamic Contribution to Medieval Philosophical Theology*). Islamic philosophers (*falasifa*), such as al-Farabi, Avicenna, and Averroës, accepted the notion of divine simplicity, whereas the Muslim theologians (*mutakallamin*) tended to reject it. Avicenna went so far as to deny that God has an essence at all. Averroës rejected this view as well as related views of Avicenna, but he, too, emphasized the importance of divine simplicity. Averroës saw simplicity and Trinity as opposed to each other; allowing composition in God would, in his view, open the way for supposing that God is triune as Christians think, contrary to the Qur'an's insistence on the unity of God. Arguing against "the philosophers," al-Ghazali, on the other hand, thought he could demonstrate that there must be composition in God, at least the composition between essence and existence.

Even in the medieval Christian tradition there wasn't universal acceptance of the doctrine of simplicity. Although he was officially condemned for this view, Gilbert of Poitiers in the twelfth century held that there is a real distinction in God between his essence and his attributes. A century later, John Duns Scotus spoke of a "formal" distinction among God's attributes, which he thought allowed him both to admit the doctrine of simplicity and also to distinguish among divine attributes. Partly in consequence of this subtle weakening of the doctrine of simplicity, Scotus thought that some terms can be applied to God and creatures univocally. William of Ockham rejected Scotus's notion of a formal distinction, but he agreed with him that some terms can be applied to God and creatures univocally, and he maintained that we can properly cognize God's essence in a concept which is both proper to it and composite.

Applications of the Concept to Issues in the Philosophy of Religion

The doctrine of divine simplicity makes a difference to several issues in the philosophy of religion, including the problem of the apparent incompatibility of omnipotence and impeccability, the seeming paradox of essential goodness, the question of God's relationship to morality, and issues related to the cosmological argument. Here I will focus just on the last two.

First, the question of God's relation to morality has typically been thought to have two possible answers. God's will is sometimes taken to create morality, in the sense that whatever God wills is good just because he wills it. This is the fundamental approach of divine command theories of morality (see Chapter 68, Divine Command Ethics). Alternatively, morality is taken to be grounded in principles transmitted by God but independent of him, so that a perfectly good God frames his will in accordance with those independently existing standards of goodness. Either of these answers seems to have a high cost attached to it. The first seems to make morality arbitrary, so that apparently anything at all could turn out to be moral (although there are sophisticated theories of divine command morality that attempt to avoid this implication). The second seems to deprive God of his sovereignty, since even God looks to standards external to him for morality. Furthermore, although this answer yields an objective morality, it does so at the cost of destroying any essential connection between morality and God.

If the doctrine of simplicity is coherent and consistent with other theistic doctrines, it can provide a third alternative. Because God is simple, he is identical with perfect goodness. Thus there is an essential relationship between God and the standard for moral goodness, and that standard is not external to God. On the other hand, because it is God's nature and not his will that is the standard, not just anything could turn out to be moral. For a simple God, then, the relation of God to perfect goodness is such that both God's sovereignty and the objectivity of morality are preserved.

Second, in the modern period, philosophers such as Gottfried Leibniz and Samuel Clarke rested their versions of the cosmological argument on the principle of sufficient reason (see Chapter 43, Cosmological Arguments). In their view, God is a necessary being, and unless we admit the existence of a necessary being, we will be unable to give a reason for the existence of something rather than nothing; in that case, contrary to the principle of sufficient reason, we will be saddled with a brute fact. One problem with this strategy for the cosmological argument is that it seems unable to account for the necessity of God's existence, which looks like a brute fact of a theological sort. If it is, then theists are in no better a position than atheists: each group has a brute fact it can't explain.

The doctrine of simplicity supplies what is lacking in versions of the cosmological argument such as Clarke's, namely, an explanation of the necessity of God's existence. Like properties, natures or essences exist in all possible worlds, if they are consistent. A simple God is identical with his nature, and so God's existence is necessary also. Someone might suppose that this line of argument just trades the brute fact of divine necessary existence for the brute fact of divine simplicity. But in fact the medievals thought that being simple is entailed by being absolutely perfect. According to them, absolute perfection requires absolute invulnerability and absolute independence, each

of which is incompatible with composition. Since they also held that “God is an absolutely perfect being” is as close as we can come to a definition of “God,” divine simplicity in their view is entailed by our very notion of God. Given the doctrine of simplicity, then, God is an entity whose necessary existence is self-explanatory in the sense that the explanation of it is provided entirely by the nature of the entity. Consequently, the doctrine of simplicity supplies what is missing in some modern versions of the cosmological argument. If God does not exist, then the search for an explanation of all contingent facts leaves at least one inexplicable contingent fact, namely, that there is something rather than nothing. But if there is an absolutely simple God, the chain of contingent facts has its ultimate explanation in a cause that is necessary and self-explanatory.

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Additional recommended readings

Petitionary prayer articles

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Divine simplicity articles

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